

Penal Policy Creative Project:
Lyrical Dance to “A Million Years Ago”

Penal Policy LAW 401D
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April 22nd, 2016

Introduction

This semester, Penal Policy taught me how little I knew about the prison system in Canada. I thought that I knew a lot about prisons, having done my undergrad in Criminal Justice. Yet I learned this year that theories and legislation are not the reality or the experience of those in prison. Our visit to Matsqui was especially enriching in this regard. After this visit, I was so full of emotion I decided that for my project I would dance through these emotions in a lyrical dance.

Reflections on Matsqui

On our three-hour drive out to Matsqui institution I recall feeling very unsettled. I had read about prisons for this class, and I had taken a corrections course in my undergrad as well. I felt as though I knew about what a prison was on paper, I knew the theories for and against and I knew the problems. Yet, I was very nervous. I had met and spoken with many people who had been in prisons throughout research I did in my undergrad. I have friends who are correctional officers, prison counselors, and parole officers. And yet, the closer we got to Matsqui, the more nervous I felt. I had no idea what the next three hours would entail.

I recall walking into the social room where we met with the inmates and shaking with nerves. However, the room was not at all how I imagined the inside of a prison would look. It was colourful, open, welcoming even. When the inmates walked into the room I was doubly surprised. They were dressed in plain clothes, each with their own unique style. Some were very social and friendly, others shy and reserved.

These were not the 'one size fits all' description of prisoners many of my undergraduate studies had taught me. These men came from all kinds of backgrounds, they came from all kinds of ethnicities and cultures, they were all different ages and yet they all looked like 'regular people'.

As we went around the circle describing why we thought studying prison was an important endeavor for lawyers I could hear my voice shake. Yet when it was the inmates' turn to speak in front of the room they were all articulate, well spoken and self-assured. What followed was one of the most enriching experiences of my life. When we split into smaller groups I was nervous that I wouldn't have enough questions to ask the inmates or that I wouldn't know what to say. In reality I could have spoken with these men for hours on end. They were passionate, smart, articulate, and speaking from the heart.

There were a few things said in our small group that really stood out to me. First, was the lack of fairness. The men we were speaking with spoke again and again over the arbitrariness involved in prison management and decision-making that pervades their daily life. They spoke about how transfers to the maximum-security institution, Kent, were used as a punishment arbitrarily for men who had never been violent but merely tried to give others a voice. They spoke about how guards would take it upon themselves to be punitive rather than following the act that governs their work. It was clear that these men felt helpless at the hands of corrections.

Secondly, it stood out to me that the men said there was a distinct lack of help for men who have drug problems and mental illness. Having worked extensively on a program evaluation of the Winnipeg Drug Treatment Court before law school, I know a fair bit about the correlation between drug addiction and crime and the importance of proper drug treatment for these individuals in reducing the risk of recidivism. Additionally, it seems plainly obvious to me that prison is not an effective means of rehabilitation for individuals who are mentally ill. It was shocking to me to hear these men speak about individuals coming to prison and “checking in” to their hotel room everyday because they were so mentally ill they did not even understand they were in prison.

Finally, I was shocked to learn of the lack of programming available to the inmates. These men are only offered up to a grade 10 education. Yet, one of the mandated purposes of prison is to prepare these men for reintegration into society. It is no wonder recidivism rates are high when men inmates are offered little to no opportunities to help them grow as people. Even men who serve life sentences are likely to be released into society eventually, and yet, as these men explained, prison does nothing to prepare them for this eventuality. The men we spoke to recalled other inmates who did not even know how to use a microwave or a washing machine and yet our society expects these men not to go back to a life of crime when they leave the institution. Hearing these men talk about how prison sets them up for

failure by teaching them no life skills, man me infuriated. This is why my creative project is based on this idea.

Expressing Frustration Through Dance

I am a dancer, I have been dancing since I was five years old, I have taught dance, competed, and choreographed. Dance is my passion. It is one of my very few creative outlets. More importantly, it is an emotional outlet for me. This is why I chose to dance out the emotions I had over the lack of programming in prisons. I was so frustrated and the only way I know to express that is through dancing.

I chose the song “A Million Years Ago” by Adele to dance to for a few reasons. First, the tone of the song is somewhat bittersweet, like how I imagine it feels to be released from prison without having gained any life skills in order to assist you with reintegration. Secondly, I thought some of the lyrics of the song were quite poignant. She sings about mistakes a person made while they were young, and how they regret the person they became. She sings about feeling alone, hating her own reflection, and feeling ashamed (looking at the floor). Through the chorus she sings,

*I feel like my life is flashing by
And all I can do is watch and cry
I miss the air, I miss my friends
I miss my mother; I miss it when
Life was a party to be thrown
But that was a million years ago*

These words reminded me of the isolation prisoners must feel while in prison. In the second verse, she sings about how the people she once knew seemed scared of her and no longer look her in the eye. This portion of the song reminded of how I imagine it must feel to be released from prison and stigmatized, despite struggling to make it in a society you are ill prepared for. All in all, this song seemed to convey the feelings of frustration, anxiety, depression, and failure that I felt when I heard the stories of inmates we spoke to.

The choreography of my dance is meant to tell the story of a person who is in prison, receives no training, is released into society, and despite their best efforts to reintegrate, fails and is incarcerated again. I dance the first half of the song with my wrists bound to symbolize the constraints of prison. The second half of the dance my hands are free to symbolize being let out into society. The beginning of this section my dancing is joyous and celebratory to represent the initial freedom experienced and an eagerness to explore society. Yet, as the song goes on my dancing becomes frustrated and anxious to represent the ill preparedness experienced by inmates released into society due to lack of programming and education while in prison. At the end of the dance my hands are bound again to represent recidivism and a return to a life of crime due to my inability to reintegrate.

Dancing to this song, and about this subject was a very difficult but rewarding experience. Having spoken to inmates personally I wanted to represent their story

accurately through dance. At the same time, I was so frustrated personally, and on their behalf, hearing their stories of lack of programming and lack of assistance in reintegration that it felt amazing to dance out my emotions through this piece. I hope you enjoy it.